

Court Halts \$1.8 Billion 'Anti-Weaponization' Fund as Primaries Heat Up

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The Justice Department will comply with a **federal court** order freezing a nearly \$1.8 billion fund designed to compensate people who claim they were targeted by the federal government, a program that has drawn sharp **bipartisan** criticism. The so-called **anti-weaponization** fund, a Trump administration priority, was meant to aid those alleging unfair treatment by federal agencies. But critics including some Republicans warned it could be used to pay individuals convicted for their roles in the January 6, 2021, Capitol attack. Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche acknowledged the court's directive during a Senate hearing last month. The pause comes as six states hold primaries Tuesday, with California and Iowa featuring the most closely watched **gubernatorial** contests. In California's top-two system, the leading candidates will advance regardless of party, setting up a potential Democratic showdown in the fall. Democrats view these races as crucial to their strategy for retaking Congress. The primary landscape also spotlights a growing debate over closed, single-party primaries, which critics argue limit voter choice and entrench party loyalty. Some lawmakers are pushing to open primaries to all voters, a move that could reshape the composition of Congress. In foreign policy news, President Trump claimed he secured pledges from Israel and **Hezbollah** to pause fighting, even as Iran suspended peace talks with the U.S. over Israel's offensive in Lebanon. The announcement followed Israeli military warnings for residents in southern Beirut to evacuate ahead of planned airstrikes. On a lighter note, tennis icon Serena Williams is returning from retirement to play doubles at the HSBC Championship in London, prompting the tournament to declare, "THE QUEEN RETURNS." And for those curious about wellness trends, NPR's "Healthy or Hype?" series examines the science behind **bovine colostrum** supplements, made from the first milk cows produce after giving birth, which influencers claim supports gut health.

Word Treasure

anti-weaponization -- A term used by the Trump administration to describe its fund for people who claim they were unfairly targeted by the government.

federal court -- A court in the national judiciary system; here, the one that issued the order freezing the fund.

bipartisan -- Involving support from both major political parties; the criticism is from both Democrats and some Republicans.

gubernatorial -- Relating to a state governor; the article mentions 'gubernatorial contests.'

Hezbollah -- A Lebanese militant group and political party; Trump claimed he secured a pause in fighting with them.

bovine colostrum -- The first milk cows produce after giving birth, used as a supplement promoted for gut health.

Background you need

The January 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol was carried out by supporters of then-President Trump trying to stop the certification of Joe Biden's election win. Hundreds were arrested and convicted; some Trump allies claimed they were unfairly targeted by the Justice Department.

The term 'weaponization of government' has been used by Trump to argue that federal agencies were used against him and his supporters, a theme that led to the creation of this fund. The court freeze highlights legal challenges to such programs.

California's 'top-two' primary system, where the two leading finishers regardless of party move on, can sometimes result in two candidates from the same party competing in November, which has sparked debate about voter choice.

Serena Williams, a 23-time Grand Slam champion who retired in 2022, is widely considered one of the greatest athletes of all time. Her return to doubles is a major sports story.

Bovine colostrum is the nutrient-rich first milk from cows after birth, and it has gained popularity among wellness influencers claiming it boosts immunity and gut health, though scientific evidence is limited.

Break it down

LEAD: Federal court freezes the \$1.8 billion anti-weaponization fund, Justice Department to comply.

+ KEY DETAIL: Acting AG Todd Blanche acknowledges directive; program had drawn bipartisan criticism.

+ JAN 6 CONNECTION: Critics worried fund could pay people convicted for Capitol attack roles.

POLITICAL CONTEXT: Six states hold primaries Tuesday, with California and Iowa's gubernatorial races most watched.

+ TOP-TWO SYSTEM: California's primary could produce same-party showdowns, fueling debate on closed primaries.

+ HOPES: Democrats see these races as crucial to retaking Congress.

FOREIGN POLICY: Trump claims Israel-Hezbollah pause, while Iran suspends peace talks over Israeli offensive in Lebanon.

LIGHTER NOTE: Serena Williams returns from retirement for HSBC Championship doubles; wellness trend on bovine colostrum supplements.

Why it matters

The freeze on the anti-weaponization fund touches core questions about justice and fairness--who gets labeled a victim of government overreach--and shows how courts can check executive plans, a lesson in separation of powers that affects every citizen.

Test what you remember

1. What is the purpose of the fund that the court froze?
 - (A) To compensate people who claim they were targeted by the federal government
 - (B) To support January 6 defendants
 - (C) To fund election campaigns
 - (D) To pay for border security
2. Who acknowledged the court's directive during a Senate hearing?
 - (A) President Trump
 - (B) Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche
 - (C) The White House press secretary
 - (D) Serena Williams
3. How many states are holding primaries on Tuesday according to the article?
 - (A) Three
 - (B) Four
 - (C) Six
 - (D) Ten
4. What foreign policy claim did President Trump make?
 - (A) He secured a nuclear deal with Iran
 - (B) He secured pledges from Israel and Hezbollah to pause fighting
 - (C) He ended the war in Ukraine
 - (D) He imposed sanctions on China
5. What tennis icon is returning to play doubles?
 - (A) Venus Williams
 - (B) Serena Williams
 - (C) Naomi Osaka
 - (D) Maria Sharapova
6. What wellness trend does NPR's series examine?
 - (A) Bovine colostrum supplements
 - (B) Keto diet
 - (C) Intermittent fasting
 - (D) Apple cider vinegar

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive:** Supporters of the fund, including some Trump allies, believe it offers a necessary remedy for those they see as unfairly prosecuted by a politically motivated Justice Department, restoring a sense of justice.
- 2. Negative / Critical:** Critics argue the fund could reward insurrectionists and send a dangerous message that political violence is acceptable, undermining the rule of law and accountability for the Capitol attack.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** The legal challenge reflects an ongoing tension: governments often create compensation programs, but when they are tied to specific political narratives, courts must weigh whether they serve a legitimate public purpose or are simply political paybacks.
- 4. Forward-looking:** If the court permanently blocks the fund, it may force the Trump administration to seek new ways to support its base, while the ongoing primaries could shift the political landscape as voters react to such debates, influencing future legislation on justice and election security.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):